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NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF DESIGN



# THE RIGHT TO IGNORE

STRATEGIC DESIGN MANAGEMENT

## HUMAN BEHAVIOUR & STRATEGIES

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# THE RIGHT TO IGNORE:

## Understanding Information Avoidance in Recreational Environments

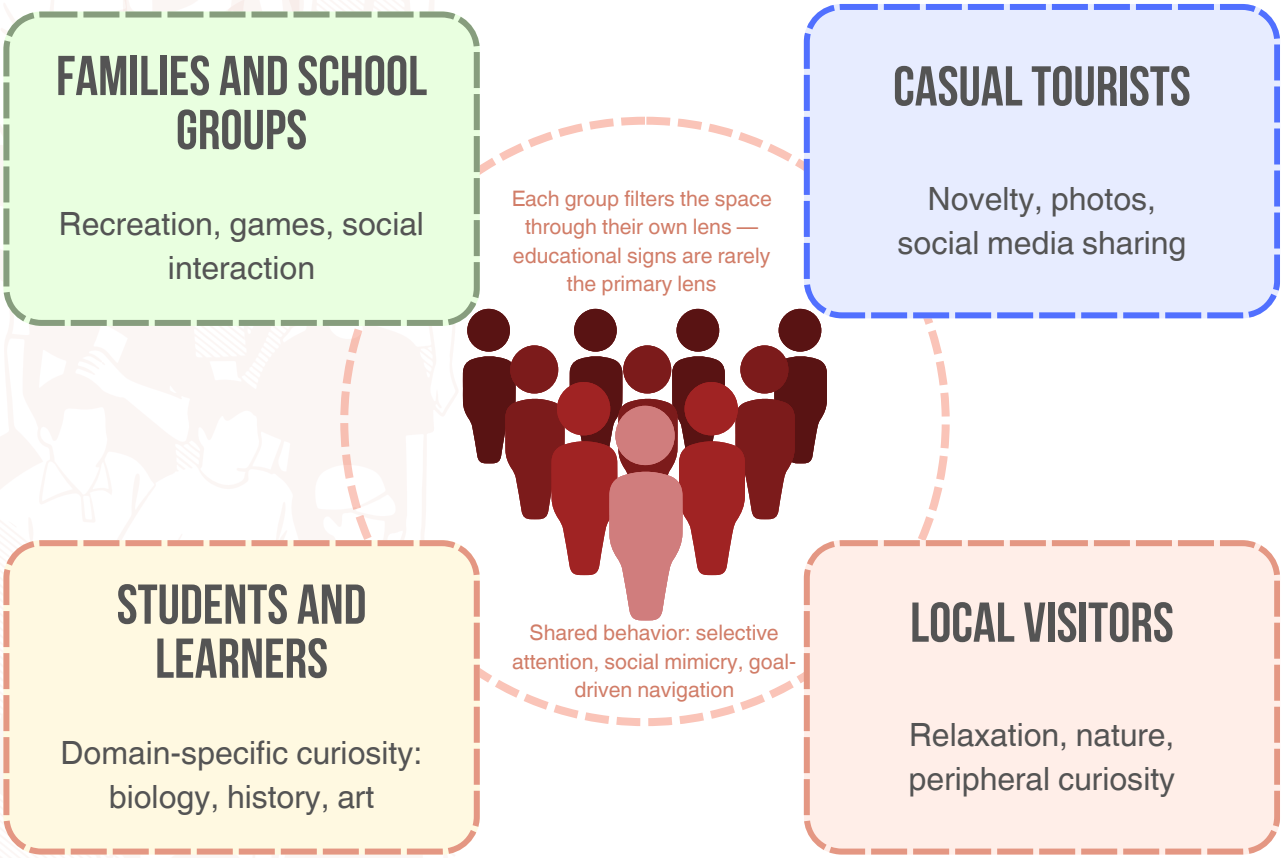

## ABSTRACT

Informal learning spaces (tourist spots/ high information zone) often assume that visitors should consume provided information (signage, labels) as a duty. Humans are inherently designed to consume information, often described as "informavores" who hunt for information to fuel their brains, much like they once hunted for food. Curiosity and information seeking are hardwired into the human brain, accessing the same reward systems as food or money. However, in the modern digital age, this natural behavior has become dysfunctional. While designed to consume information, humans are not designed to consume the volume and type of information available today. So the expectations of such spaces cannot be solely fulfilled because it was assumed to be a duty or righteous behavior. When information does not match a visitor's interest or interrupt their flow, it is easily ignored, that is a predictable outcome, not a moral failing. Now, visitors enter such spaces with their own goals (leisure, socializing, photography, etc.) and selectively attend only what fits those goals. This white paper examines who defines "proper" behavior, contrasting institutional expectations (quiet contemplation, reading all labels) with visitor motivations and psychological realities. Evidence from visitor studies shows that passive content is often overlooked and that interactive, curiosity-driven, or sensory-rich stimuli are needed to capture attention. The argument is that disengagement is a form of agency and selective attention, not ignorance. In an era of information overload, visitors should not be shamed for tuning out uninteresting data. Rather, designers and institutions should prioritize visitors' needs and design for engagement, rather than blame them for choosing to relax or explore in other ways.

# INTRODUCTION: CONTEXT AND CROWD

The crowd is diverse in these spaces; it's a mix of families, school groups, tourists, couples, hobbyists, and casual strollers. Each visitor brings a mix of intentions, like leisure goals and learning interests. For example, many come to Indroda Nature Park simply to enjoy the outdoors or photograph dinosaur models with friends, and for them, reading educational signs is secondary. Modern museum studies emphasize on visitor centered perspective, meaning people visit only when they perceive it meets their needs. The "audience" expects an experience, not a boundary or controlled lectures, often leisure, social time, or novelty. As John Falk notes, museums traditionally debate "quality/education" vs "quantity/entertainment," but this frames the issue from the museum's perspective. If we turn the lens as visitor-centered, the question might be framed: what do visitors value? It finds that they seek a variety of self-related goals, only some of which involve content or information consumption. In other words, visitors are consumers of experience, not passive pupils.

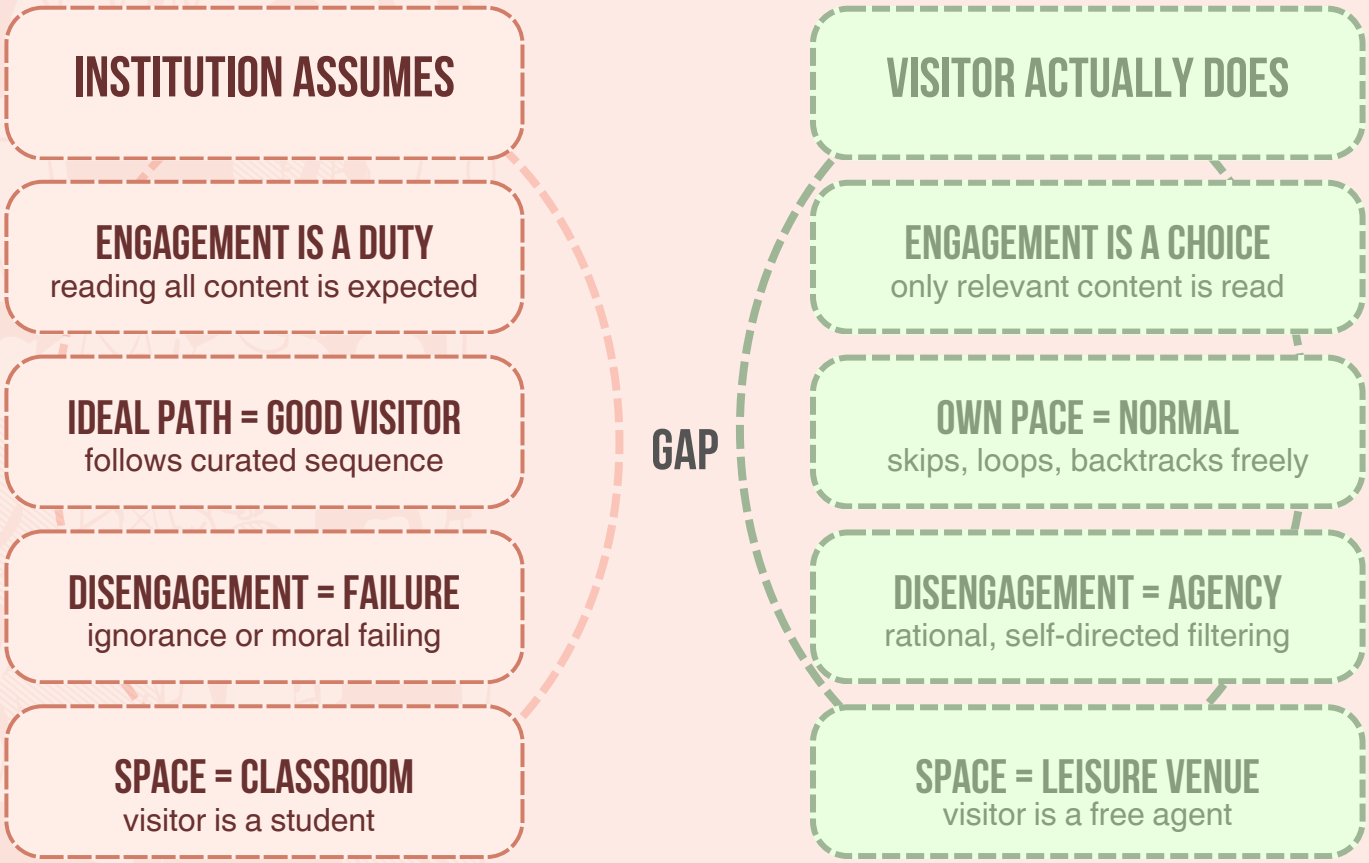
At Indroda and similar tourist places, the crowd typically includes:



Social proof (herd mentality) plays a significant role as individuals often mimic the behavior of those around them, leading to collective tendencies to ignore informational signage in favor of personal engagement, such as taking photos or chatting. The environment itself, such as park vs quiet art museum, also cues behavior that are ingraved in our subconcious. Parks signals “play and explore” whereas the white-walled galleries signals “quiet study.” When spaces blend these cues (a park with educational signs), tension arises between visitor intention and institutional expectation.

## INSTITUTIONAL EXPECTATIONS VS VISITOR REALITY

Most museums/parks publish rules and guidance as a list of “expected behaviors.” Such as, art museums emphasize silence and no flash photography to protect artworks, whereas parks forbid feeding animals or entering water for safety. But beyond safety, there is also an unstated expectation: visitors should read and appreciate the information we provide. In formal terms, institutions assume visitors will engage with all labeled content as a duty, whereas they view otherwise as “ignorance or moral failing.” But who made these rules?



These differing views create a gap. The institution is the “content authority,” expecting visitors to be students of the exhibits. But the visitor is an outsider making a free choice. This divergence creates a perceptible tension where institutions acting as authorities view disengagement as a moral failing. Falk (2016) suggests reframing the question: rather than asking what behavior is “correct,” we should inquire what visitors truly seek in their experience. The answer suggests that educational engagement is only one among many motivations and should not be deemed the only valid perspective.

Every space carries within it an invisible architecture of expectation. Long before a visitor steps through the door, decisions have already been made on their behalf: what they should notice, how long they should linger, what counts as meaningful. These decisions belong, almost exclusively, to the institution. The people who build the world inside the walls are the same people who quietly decide how that world ought to be inhabited. And so a hierarchy is born, rarely spoken aloud but felt in every sign, every rope barrier, every carefully worded label.

This is the institution's dream of the visitor: attentive, unhurried, pausing at each label, departing enriched. It is not an ignoble dream. But it is, for the vast majority of actual visitors on any actual day, almost entirely fictional.

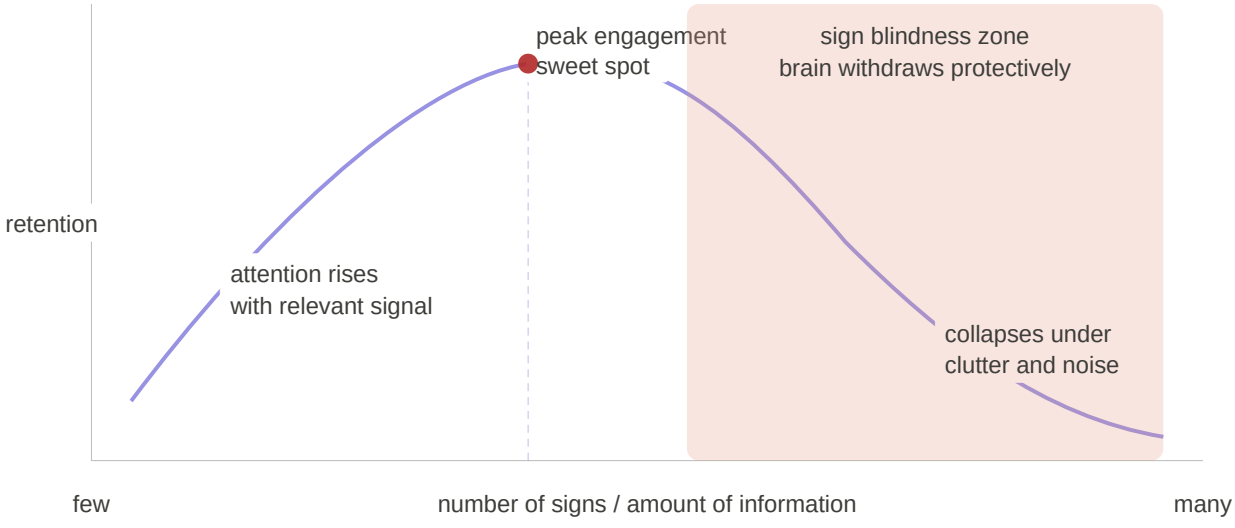
*FALK'S REFRAME: NOT "WHAT IS CORRECT BEHAVIOR? "BUT " WHAT DO VISITORS TRULY SEEK?" ONLY SOME OF IT IS EDUCATIONAL*



# THE PSYCHOLOGY OF ATTENTION AND INFORMATION ENGAGEMENT

Cognitive psychology explains that human attention is a limited resource. In stimulating environments, individuals filter out information that does not immediately capture their interest. This phenomenon is well documented; studies indicate that “sign blindness” occurs when excessive text or irrelevant details are present.

Sign blindness: what happens as information accumulates




Visual clutter doesn't just fail to inform — it actively diminishes retention of everything around it.

## The Scarcity of Attention

**~11 million** bits/sec

Human brain processing capacity

**~40–50** bits/sec

Capacity of conscious attention handling

Cognitive psychology has long understood what institutional designers have been slower to accept: that attention is not a tap that can be turned on by demand. It is a finite, fragile, and deeply selective faculty, one that evolved not to absorb everything but to identify what matters. In the rich sensory environment of a museum, a park, or a heritage site, this selectivity becomes especially pronounced. The visitor who walks past a densely worded panel is not being careless. They are being human. Their mind has already, in fractions of a second, assessed the signal and found it insufficient to justify the cognitive cost of full engagement.

Average focused attention span dropped from

**~12 seconds (2000)**

to

**~8 seconds**

(recent estimates)

This is what researchers have come to call sign blindness, a phenomenon as predictable as it is underappreciated by those who design interpretive environments. When text accumulates, when warnings multiply, when every surface competes equally for notice, the brain responds not with expanded attention but with a kind of protective withdrawal. Visual clutter does not merely fail to inform. It actively diminishes the retention of everything around it, drowning signal in noise until the whole environment begins to feel like background. Wolf recognized this decades ago, and yet the instinct to add more, to say more, to cover every contingency with another label, has proven remarkably resistant to the evidence.

People spend less than

**20%**

of time actually

**reading text**

on a page

**15–30**

**seconds**

per exhibit

**2–5**

**seconds**

scanning labels before deciding to read or skip

## The Deep Logic of Relevance

But attention is not simply rationed randomly. It flows, with surprising fidelity, toward what already matters to the person doing the attending. Falk's work on visitor identity and motivation illuminates this with particular clarity: personal relevance is not one factor among many in determining engagement. It is the precondition for engagement. Information that does not speak to a visitor's existing interests, that does not brush against something they already care about or wonder about or feel, will pass through awareness like light through glass, leaving almost no trace.

Attention to any single sign drops by up to

**50%**

When multiple signs compete.

**60–80%**

of signage in public spaces is ignored entirely

"Visual clutter" can reduce comprehension by up to

**30–40%**

This is not a flaw in the visitor. It is a feature of the mind that serves us extraordinarily well in most circumstances. In a world of infinite information, the ability to filter ruthlessly for what matters is not ignorance. It is, as Girasek observed, a rational navigational strategy, the cognitive equivalent of choosing a path through wilderness. The visitor who ignores a sign about geological formations while pausing, transfixed, before an unexpected view of the valley below is not failing to learn. They are learning something, just something the institution did not plan for and perhaps cannot measure.

The implications for design are profound and uncomfortable. If relevance is the gateway through which all engagement must pass, then no amount of informational content, however accurate, however beautifully worded, will reach a visitor whose motivations lie elsewhere. The institution cannot manufacture relevance from the outside. It can only create conditions in which the visitor's own curiosity, already alive and already searching, finds something worth meeting.

**Visitors remember:**

**~10%**

of what they read

**~50%**

of what connects to prior interest

**~80%**

of what they actively engage with

Multi-sensory experiences improve retention by up to

**75%**

vs passive reading

**2x**

Increased engagement time when the format is story based.

**40%**

improved memory retention by curiosity-driven experience

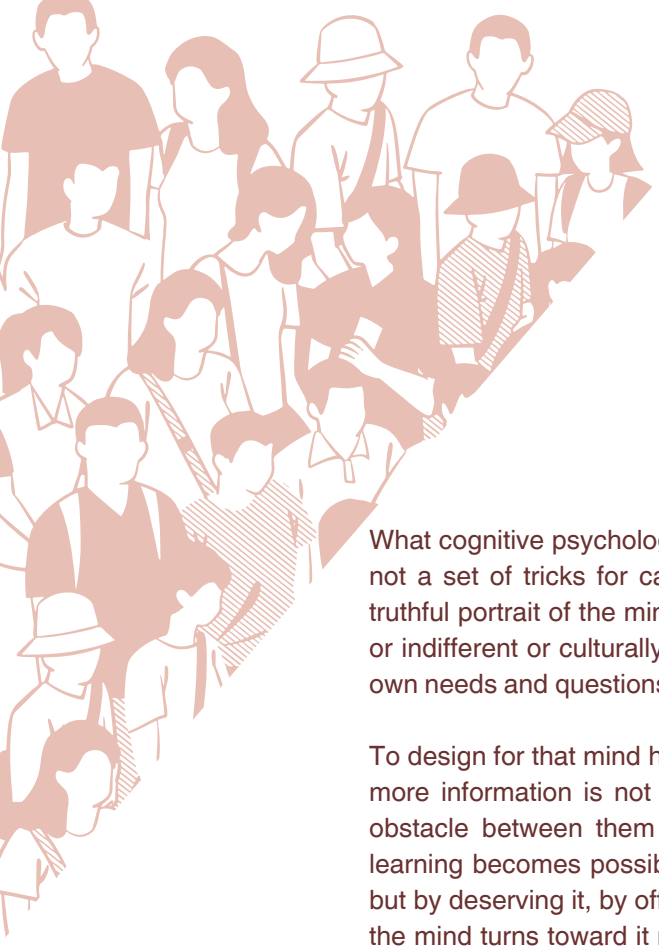
## The Spark of Curiosity

Here, finally, is where the psychology of attention offers not just diagnosis but possibility. Because while attention cannot be commanded, it can be seduced. Curiosity, that most ancient and generous of human impulses, does not wait to be given permission. It reaches, spontaneously and irresistibly, toward the unexpected, the unresolved, the quietly strange. And when a space understands this, when it designs not for compliance but for interruption of the ordinary, something shifts.

The dinosaur sound drifting unexpectedly down a forest path. The intriguing question suspended from a tree branch where a label was never expected to be. The exhibit that begins not with an answer but with a mystery, that leans toward the visitor and whispers: did you know? These are not gimmicks. They are invitations issued in the precise language that human attention has always responded to. They work because they do not ask the visitor to abandon their own inner world and enter the institution's. They find the visitor exactly where they are and offer them something genuinely worth the turn of a head.

Multi-sensory cues, narrative structure, the deliberate disruption of expectation: museum educators have understood the power of these tools for generations, even if institutional design has not always trusted them enough to let them lead. The research is consistent and compelling. Exhibits that provoke questions rather than deliver answers, that engage the body as well as the mind, that tell stories with a beginning and an arc and a moment of genuine surprise, hold attention longer, generate deeper processing, and leave traces in memory that outlast the visit itself.

*Curiosity increases memory retention by **~30–40%***



## Reading the Mind the Space Was Built For

What cognitive psychology ultimately offers to the designers of informal learning spaces is not a set of tricks for capturing distracted visitors. It is something more fundamental: a truthful portrait of the mind the space was built for. That mind is not deficient. It is not lazy or indifferent or culturally impoverished. It is finite, purposeful, and exquisitely tuned to its own needs and questions.

To design for that mind honestly is to accept that passive content will rarely penetrate, that more information is not always more, and that the visitor's selective attention is not an obstacle between them and learning but the very mechanism through which any real learning becomes possible. The space that earns attention does so not by demanding it, but by deserving it, by offering something so genuinely curious, so unexpectedly alive, that the mind turns toward it not out of obligation, but out of the oldest human instinct there is: the desire to know.

*Interactive exhibits can increase visitor engagement time by up to **4×.***

**People remember:**

**10%**
of what they read

**20%**
of what they hear

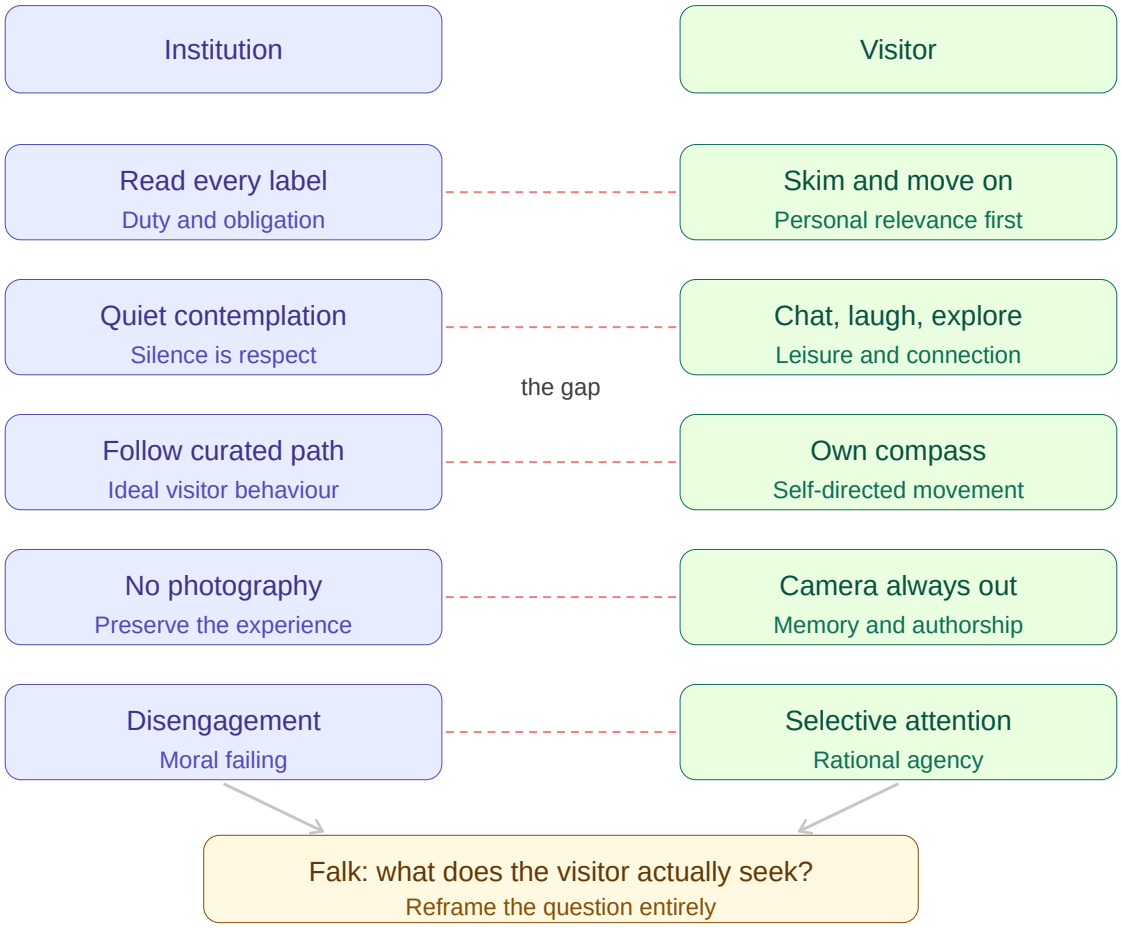
**80-90%**
of what they do



# WHO DECIDES WHAT IS RIGHT?

Every space carries within it an invisible architecture of expectation. Long before a visitor steps through the door, decisions have already been made on their behalf: what they should notice, how long they should linger, what counts as meaningful. These decisions belong, almost exclusively, to the institution. The people who build the world inside the walls are the same people who quietly decide how that world ought to be inhabited.

And so a hierarchy is born, rarely spoken aloud but felt in every sign, every rope barrier, every carefully worded label.## Institutional Expectations vs. Visitor Reality




## Institutional Expectations vs. Visitor Reality

There is a particular silence that settles over a well-designed gallery. Hushed, reverent, deliberate. A silence that says: this is a serious place, and seriousness is expected of you. Beneath the posted rules and careful arrangements lies an unwritten contract: pay attention to what we have prepared for you. This is the institution's dream of the visitor. And it is, for the vast majority of actual people on any actual day, almost entirely fictional.

## The Script and the Person Who Never Read It

Institutions write their expectations into the very grammar of their spaces. Exhibit layouts suggest sequences. Label placement implies reading order. The model patron who follows the ideal path and honors the curatorial narrative is less a description of a real human being than a projection of institutional hope. Real visitors arrive carrying their own lives: a couple celebrating an anniversary, a parent trying to spark something in a restless child, a group of friends who chose this over a dozen other ways to spend their afternoon. They enter not as students reporting for instruction but as free agents, navigating the space with their own compass.

## Two Languages, One Room

The gap between institutional expectation and visitor reality is a gap between two different understandings of what the space is for. The institution speaks the language of education and curated meaning. The visitor often speaks the language of leisure, connection, and personal discovery. Both are legitimate. But they are frequently spoken past each other, in the same room, without either party fully realizing the other is not listening.

***"PEOPLE DON'T COME TO MUSEUMS TO BE TOLD. THEY COME TO CONNECT." - NINA SIMON (MUSEUM DESIGN)***

Visitors consistently perceive museums and parks as leisure environments, not compulsory classrooms where disengagement carries moral weight. Skipping a panel to take a photograph is not negligence. It is a coherent response to a moment that offered something more immediately meaningful. Yet the institution has historically reached for a troubling interpretation: disengagement becomes ignorance, selective attention becomes moral failing. This judgment, embedded in the design logic of countless spaces, positions the institution as righteous and the visitor as deficient, when the more honest reading is simply that two sets of expectations met and failed to find common ground.

***"INFORMATION IS NOT INTERPRETATION." -FREEMAN TILDEN (INTERPRETATION THEORY)***

***"VISITORS CONSTRUCT THEIR OWN EXPERIENCES." -FALK***

***"ATTENTION IS THE MOST IMPORTANT RESOURCE WE HAVE." - CSIKSZENTMIHALYI***

**70%**
of visitors prioritize experience over learning

**<20%**
of exhibit text is actually read

**80-90%**
visitors report satisfaction despite selective engagement

## Reframing the Question

Falk's contribution is simple but quietly revolutionary. Rather than asking what visitor behavior is correct, he asks what visitors are truly seeking. Educational engagement is only one motivation among many. Visitors seek restoration, social connection, wonder, and the pleasure of time spent on their own terms. These are not lesser than the desire for learning. In many cases, they are the very conditions under which real learning becomes possible at all.

The tension between institutional expectation and visitor reality is not inevitable. It is a design choice that can be unmade, beginning with the willingness to ask, with genuine humility, not what visitors should be doing, but what they are actually doing and why. The institution that holds that question with curiosity rather than judgment will find, waiting in the answer, a far more honest version of itself.

***2×***

*higher memory when content feels personally relevant*

# WHO DECIDES?
# THE TRIANGLE OF AUTHORITY

The question of who decides what is right inside an informal learning space does not have a single answer. Authority is not held by one hand but distributed across three forces in a constant, largely unspoken negotiation.

### Curators and management:

They write the labels, set exhibit rules, and implicitly shape the "proper" experience. They often assume learning is the default goal and that visitors should conform to curator intent. Their authority stems from expertise and institutional mission (education, preservation).

### Market forces:

To some extent, visitor behavior is also regulated by "the market" – museums compete for attention. Many museums now allow photography and design interactive exhibits precisely because visitor surveys show pure contemplation isn't always what people want

### The visitors themselves:

Ultimately, each visitor "votes" with their behavior. If most skip an exhibit or ignore signage, eventually designers take note (if they are astute). For example, one park study found a novel sign focusing on legal fines reduced dangerous behavior by **63%**, demonstrating that clear, targeted messages can change behavior – but only when visitors pay attention.

## The Curators and the Keepers

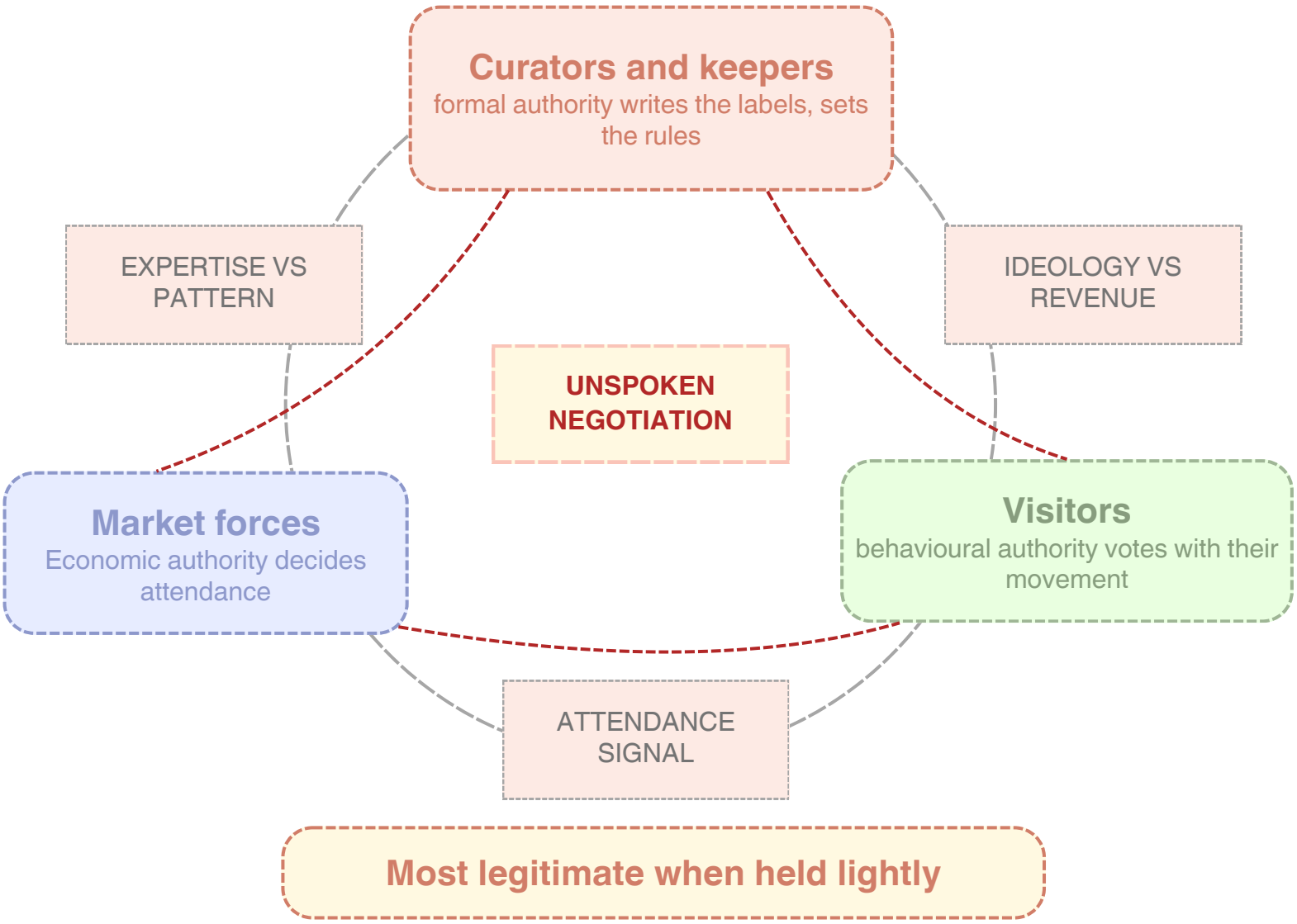
At the most visible apex stand the curators, educators, and managers. They write the labels, arrange the rooms, and decide what deserves a spotlight. Their authority is earned through expertise and genuine commitment to preservation and education. But belief, however sincere, is not the same as reality. The assumption that visitors should conform to curatorial intent quietly smuggles in a paternalism that positions the institution as the rightful author of the visitor's experience, designing not around who the visitor is, but who the institution believes they should become. It is a generous impulse, but ultimately a one-sided conversation.

## The Pressure of the Market

Below institutional idealism, a second force operates with rather less sentiment. The market does not care about curatorial intent. It cares about whether people come and return. Museums that once banned cameras have softened, not because their philosophy changed, but because visitor surveys made the cost of rigidity plain. Market forces accomplished what decades of visitor studies struggled to achieve: they made institutions listen. Encouraging, because visitor preferences eventually reshape institutional behavior. Unsettling, because it means the primary lever for change is economic rather than ethical.

## The Visitor's Quiet Vote

The third force is the most diffuse and most democratic. Visitors do not write policy, but their accumulated choices are irresistible. Every skipped panel, every unexpected pause, every raised camera is a vote cast without words. One national park study found that targeted, consequence-specific signage reduced dangerous behavior by sixty three percent, not because visitors were lectured more forcefully, but because the message was finally relevant enough to earn their attention. The visitor's vote is not opposition. It is an offer of collaboration, if only the institution is willing to read it honestly.



*The triangle above maps the three forces. Now here is how their authority actually breaks down and who has historically dominated.*

| FORCE | TYPE OF AUTHORITY | HISTORICAL WEIGHT | HONEST ROLE |
|---|---|---|---|
| CURATORS AND KEEPERS | FORMAL | DOMINANT (always heard) | Set the frame |
| MARKET FORCES | ECONOMIC | Occational disruptors | Force change |
| VISITORS THEMSELVES | BEHAVIORAL | Noted last | Truest data |

***63% REDUCTION***

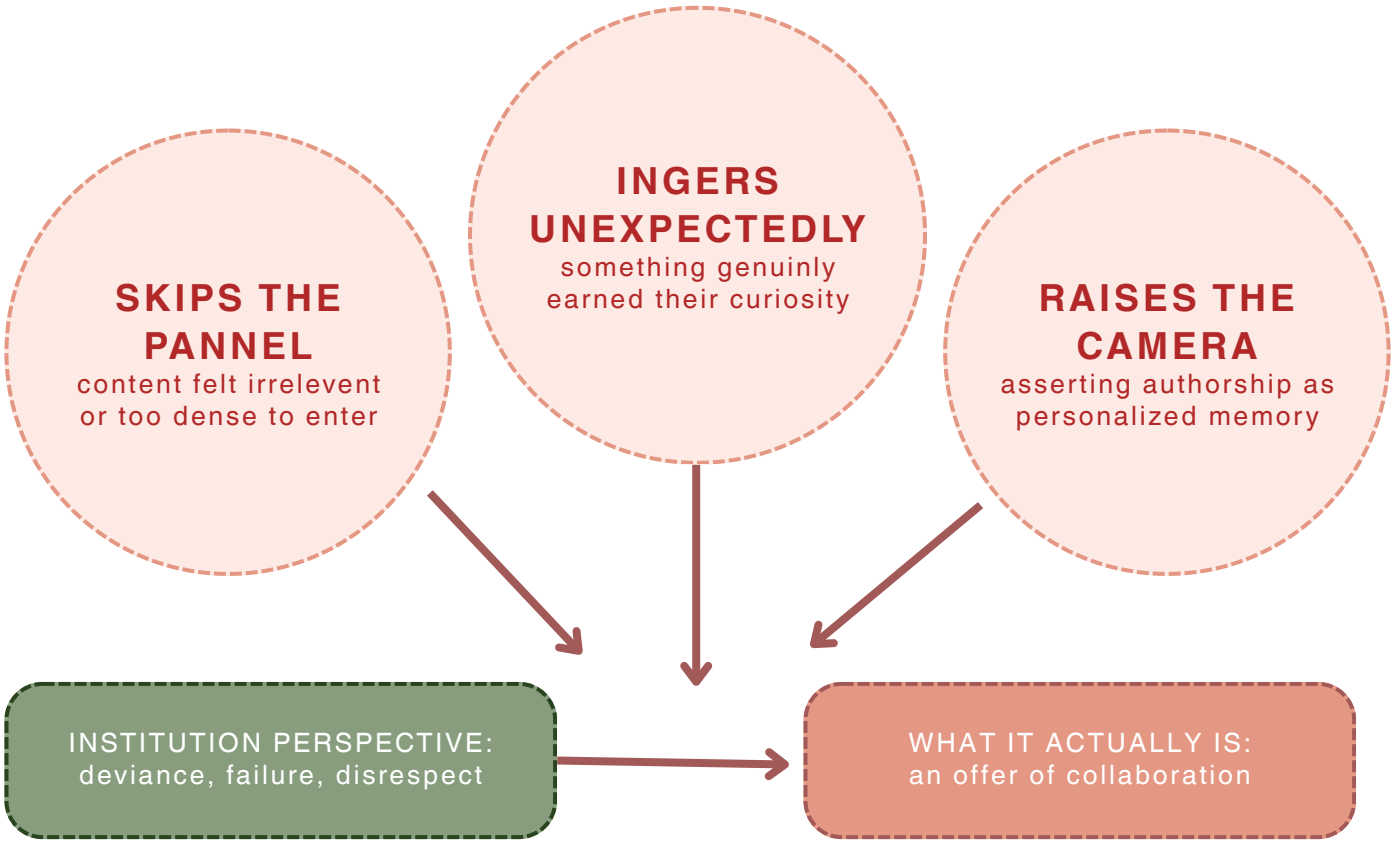
*in dangerous behavior when signage became targeted and consequence-specific —not because visitors were lectured harder, but because the message finally earned their attention.*

## A Triangle in Need of Rebalancing

Curators hold formal authority. Markets hold economic authority. Visitors hold behavioral authority. For most of history, the first has dominated, the second has occasionally disrupted, and the third has been noted only when impossible to ignore. A more honest model would begin with who the visitor already is, treat market signals as democratic feedback, and recognize the visitor's quiet accumulated choices as the most truthful data the institution will ever receive. Authority, in the end, is most legitimate when held lightly, when it invites rather than instructs, and when it remains genuinely curious about the people it was built to serve.

*And finally, what each force actually looks like in practice — the gap between how institutions hear these voices versus how loud they really are.*

**The visitor's quiet vote — what each behavior signals**




*The most truthful data an institution receives, if it is willing to read it honestly.*

# IMPLICATIONS AND REFRAMING

To enhance visitor experiences, institutions must acknowledge the diversity of visitor motivations and adapt their approaches. Here are some insights based on the data:

1

**Focus on Relevance and Engagement:** Information should be designed to align with diverse visitor interests, sparking curiosity rather than adhering to an obligation to read every sign. This approach goes beyond merely presenting content to actively engaging visitors in their experiences.

2

**Streamline Communication:** Clarity is essential. Research shows that concise and unambiguous information attracts more attention than cluttered displays. Signage should be clear and devoid of excessive text to minimize cognitive overload and enhance noticeability.

3

**Embrace Multi-modal and Interactive Elements:** Engaging exhibits that incorporate storytelling or multi-sensory experiences can dramatically increase visitor interest. Museums that provoke inquiries or present interesting narratives tend to retain more attention than static displays.

4

**Acknowledge Visitor Choice:** It is essential to respect the right of visitors to disengage. If the information presented is irrelevant to them, their choice to ignore it is a reflection of personal priorities rather than a failure to engage.

5

**Leverage Data for Enhanced Design:** Visitor engagement data should inform exhibit planning and design decisions. Utilizing both qualitative insights and quantitative metrics will help venues create immersive experiences that resonate with actual visitor behaviors.

# CONCLUSION:
# REFRAMING THE VISITOR CONTRACT

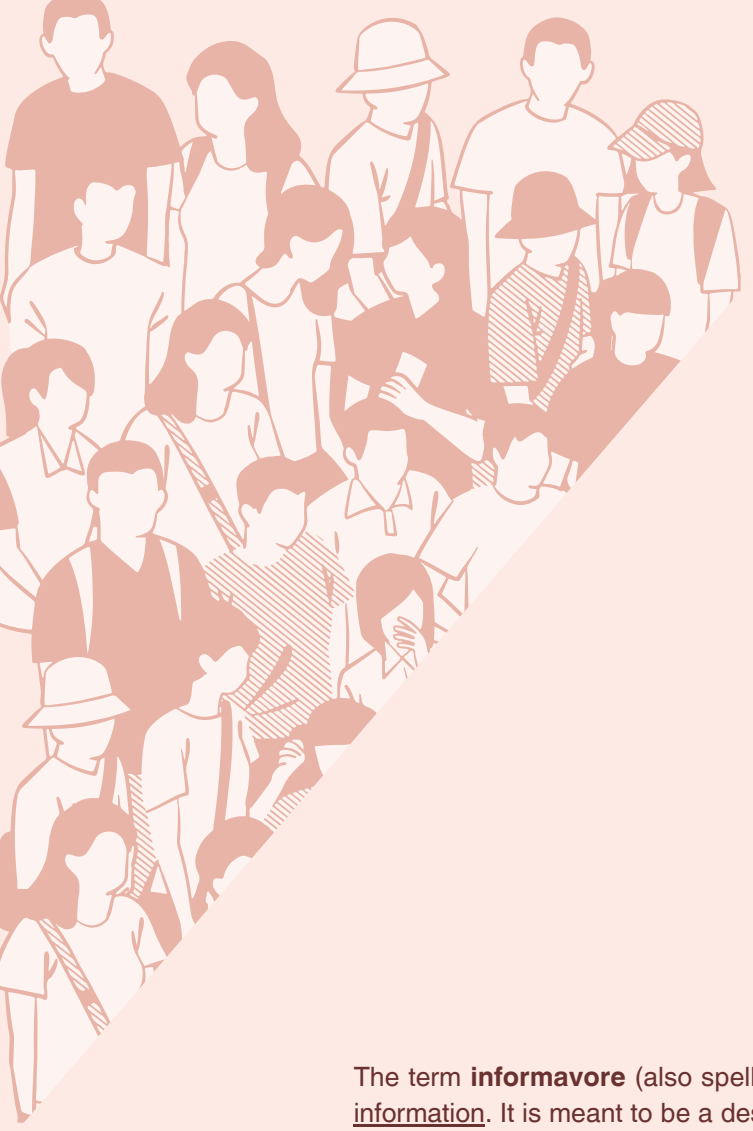
The central provocation of this paper has been to challenge a deeply embedded institutional assumption: that visitors who do not read every label or absorb every piece of interpretive content are somehow failing in their role. This framing imposes a behavioral contract on visitors that was never negotiated and is, as the evidence demonstrates, fundamentally at odds with how human cognition actually operates.

Humans are informavores by nature, curiosity-driven, and wired to pursue information that is novel, relevant, and personally meaningful. Yet the modern world now floods those same cognitive systems with volumes of information that no single mind was ever built to absorb. What emerges from this collision is not apathy, but adaptation. Selective attention and goal-directed behavior are the quiet, rational responses of a finite being learning to navigate an infinite stream. When a visitor walks past an interpretive panel without pausing, they are not failing the space. They are listening to something else, something that called to them first.

The institutional habit of defining "proper" visitor behavior reflects a didactic model that has long privileged the institution's voice over the visitor's inner life. Perhaps this posture once made sense, in quieter times when knowledge was scarce, and a museum wall held something the world outside could not offer. But that world has dissolved. To keep designing for a visitor conditioned to passively receive curated wisdom is to design for a ghost.

What is needed, then, is not a lower standard for visitors but a deeper imagination in design. Interpretive content must earn its place in the visitor's awareness, not by demanding attention as a duty, but by meeting visitors where their curiosity already lives. And institutions must grow more honest about what learning truly means in these spaces. A family that spends an afternoon in shared laughter and wandering wonder, having read perhaps only a handful of signs, may leave carrying something far more lasting than any fact. Learning here is not the transfer of information from wall to mind. It is the slow construction of meaning, woven from emotion, memory, and human presence.

In an age of relentless information, the most generous thing an informal learning space can offer is not more content, but a gentler contract: one that treats its visitors as intelligent, self-directed souls whose attention is not owed, but earned, and whose simplest moments of joy are not failures of engagement, but its quietest, most honest form.



# GLOSSARY

The term **informavore** (also spelled informivore) characterizes an organism that consumes information. It is meant to be a description of human behavior in modern information society, in comparison to omnivore, as a description of humans consuming food.

**visitor-centered perspective:** A visitor-centered perspective prioritizes the needs, emotions, and motivations of the user over the institution's internal agenda, aiming to make museums, attractions, or services personally meaningful. It shifts focus from purely content-driven curation to interactive experiences that facilitate learning, engagement, and enjoyment for a diverse audience.

**Ignoble** is an adjective describing actions, motives, or character that are dishonorable, base, or shameful. It often implies a lack of high moral purpose or noble quality, typically used to describe petty, mean, or unworthy behavior.

**Quiet contemplation** is the practice of intentional stillness and deep reflection, allowing for increased mental clarity, emotional regulation, and creativity.

**Cognitive psychology** is the scientific study of internal mental processes—how people perceive, remember, think, speak, learn, and solve problems.

If you are **transfixed** by something, it captures all of your interest or attention, so that you are unable to think of anything else or unable to act.

**Apathy:** It is a state of indifference, and/or the suppression of emotions such as concern, excitement, motivation, or passion.

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